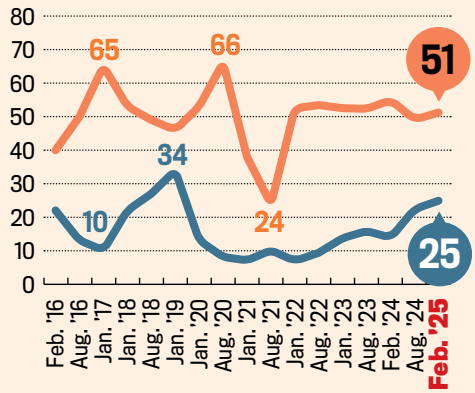
NARENDRA MODI vs RAHUL GANDHI

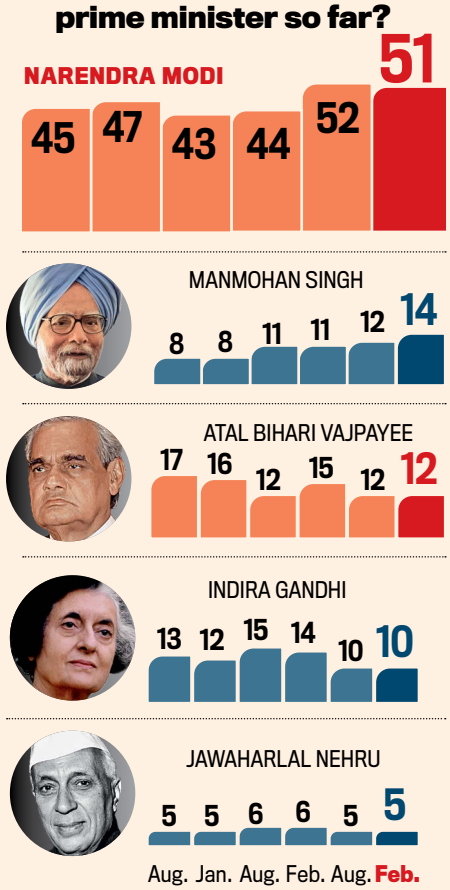
How MOTN surveys reflected the public mood on the choice of PM candidate between the two leaders



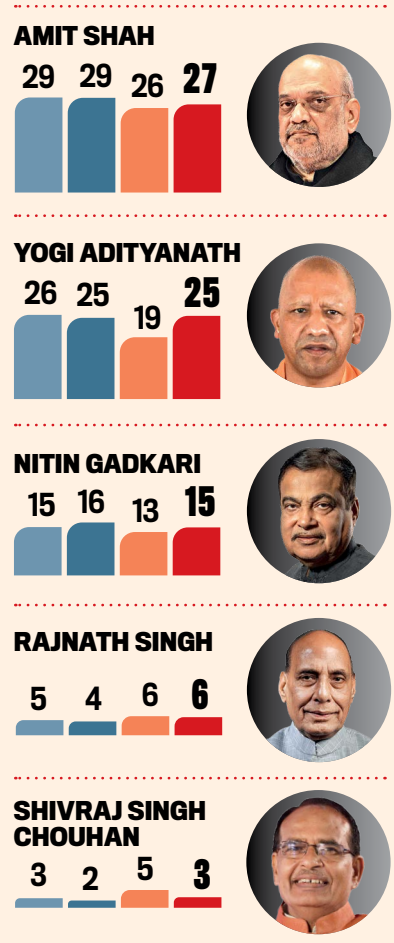
CHANDRADEEP KUMAR



Q. Who has been India's best prime minister so far?



Q. Who is best suited to succeed Modi as the BJP's prime ministerial candidate?



49%

of the privileged caste Hindus view Prime Minister Narendra Modi's performance as outstanding compared to 34% SC respondents

47%

of the respondents in North India rate Modi's performance as outstanding compared to 27% in South India

extend to the distribution of cabinet portfolios, though, as the PM not only kept key ministries such as finance, home, external affairs and defence for the BJP but also retained much of his core team. In that sense, Modi 3.0 is a continuation of Modi 2.0. If earlier the perception was that the BJP could not do without Narendra Modi, now it seems that the NDA would not be stable without him.

This is in sharp contrast to where INDIA, especially the Congress, stand. Their bluster after the general election has descended into a slanging match against each other. The INDIA bloc's tally is projected as coming down from 234 to 188—a drop of 46 seats, with the Congress taking the maximum hit. The Grand Old Party's tally slips by 21 seats—from 99 to 78. INDIA's maximum losses come from Maharashtra where it won 30 of the 48 seats, compared to the NDA's 17. The MOTN indicates that the NDA's tally would now go up to 40 seats, a 23-seat addition from Maharashtra alone.

Elsewhere, in Rajasthan and Haryana, where the Congress had eaten into the BJP's tally, the saffron party seems to have rebounded. In Uttar Pradesh, where the BJP won just 33 out of the state's 80 Lok Sabha seats, it gains 11 seats in the MOTN, at the expense of the Congress and Akhilesh Yadav's Samajwadi Party, which won six and 37 seats, respectively, in last year's general election. The NDA's tally is around 44, still far short of the 64 it won in 2019. In other big states such as West Bengal and Tamil Nadu, regional parties like the Trinamool Congress and the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam hold firm, with both Mamata Banerjee and M.K. Stalin figur-